



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 46

VIRGINIA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Virginia's family courts and child-welfare system.

61

VIRGINIA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 103
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 22 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 26, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
27 OF 133

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

VIRGINIA AT A GLANCE.

Across 61 Virginia families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 103 60 of 61 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$15,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 22 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 68.9% 36.1% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 61	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.7	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 60 of 61	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 27

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Virginia families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](#)

02

THE COST OF VIRGINIA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	36	\$15,000	\$55,250	\$1,989,000
Lost Wages	25	\$10,000	\$64,580	\$1,614,500
Other Court Fees	19	\$2,000	\$3,774	\$71,700
Therapy / Evaluations	22	\$2,000	\$33,873	\$745,200
Reunification Services	16	\$0	\$1,319	\$21,100
GAL Fees	21	\$3,000	\$22,240	\$467,044
Asset Loss ¹	24	\$30,750	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$62,750	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$30,750) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		22	1.8 yrs
Mean months lost		33	2.8 yrs
Total across all families		1,135	94.6 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · VIRGINIA

Most families documenting in Virginia are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		25	41%
Not provided		21	34%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		7	11%
Case closed: within last 2 years		5	8%
I am not currently in court but still affected		2	3%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		25	41%
Family Court Only		18	30%
Unknown		11	18%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		6	10%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		18	30%
5 – 10 years		13	21%
Over 10 years		6	10%
3 – 5 years		5	8%
5+ years		5	8%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		22	36%
Visitation Only		14	23%
50/50 Joint		8	13%
Children in Foster Care		6	10%
Full Custody		6	10%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Chesterfield		3	5%
Prince William		3	5%
Franklin		2	3%
Russell		2	3%
Virginia Beach		2	3%
Henrico And Goochland		2	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		18	30%
Other: (Short answer)		9	15%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		8	13%
Environmental/Poverty-Related (Lack of housing, utilities, etc.)		4	7%
High Conflict Divorce		3	5%

05 PARENT VOICES — VIRGINIA

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



This system has destroyed our family bond, caused us to miss new memories that would have made and have utterly traumatized my grandsons even further, they have traumatized me and my family beyond repair. What has happened to our family, I pray it never happens to any more [...]

— MINISTER CHERYL

The system has destroyed an stolen my family for the last 2 years and possibly for the next 8 years until my children age out.

— HAYLEY

Completely destroyed our lives, we lost everything and are still fighting tooth and nail to get it back but it's been made incredibly difficult.

— SIDNEY

The system has traumatized, alienated, drained us financially and emotionally, caused my son PTSD, and attempted to destroy us. They have appointed GALs that did not do what they are required by state law, not included us in any of the investigation, been bias, making [...]

— (DEMETRICE) INEZ

Completely and utterly destroyed me my kids and all of our hopes, dreams, milestones, and moments. They stole everything from us.

— ERIC

It's destroyed the Fabric of innocence for Children and Families in a Country that's supposed to protect it.

— RAMON

This corrupt system has stolen my son's and my happiness, our rights seem to not matter at all. My son is so sad all the time because of this corruption with his father and the courts. All he wants is to come back home with his momma & sisters.

— KRYSTAL

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Systemic corruption with GAL program, bias/non-neutrality/withholding material changes and sexual abuse disclosure from court/failure to investigate, I could literally go on

— KELLY

The system has robbed my youngest son the chance to grow up with his older brother and the system violated my rights and ignored the UCCJEA

— ALISON

They have hurt my children and myself putting my babies in a horrible situation with physical abuse , sexual abuse separated my twins and alienated them from whole family where they were safe and loved

— APREAL

Due to false allegations, I lost my house, car, child, and freedom in less than 10 minutes.

— MICHAEL

Broke my children right caused them mental abuse and caused them years of trauma. Broke my constitutional right caused me trauma. Helped the other party to to cause them mental and physical abuse. Both of my children have been put in situations that have caused them mental and [...]

— KATHRYN

Emotional abuse in a time of need . Destroyed my family and home and myself every joy in my wonderful life is gone. They killed my soul and I'm alone in the world completely..

— AARAH

My sister lost her children for staying in an abusive relationship. I lost mine for leaving. As women, there was no path that led to protection.

— SARA

The corruption in our judicial system cost me the ability to provide the life my children deserved on a regular basis and often the loss of stable, structured, nurturing time together. My experience is minor compared to many others, yet it matters and is an indicator of a huge [...]

— VALARIE

Mentally destroyed a child. He will never recover from being taken away from his Mom and 4 years old and given to a Dad that physically and mentally abused him.

— MCKENZIE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



We have been incredibly traumatized and devastated by what has occurred over the past 2 1/2 years. We miss our children and the moments we're being prohibited from sharing with them every single day.

— WHITNEY

Inflicted lifelong trauma and distrust of the system

— KIMBERLY

Destroyed my relationship with both of my sons went from four days weekly sometimes five to 0 literally all for a check and bitterness all rights where violated

— CHRIS

Destroyed me financially, caused defamation of my status as a mother, caused me to develop cptsd, anxiety and more. Same for my child.

— JULIE

Caused PTSD for me, and my family. It has caused tremendous and traumatic damage to myself and my fiancé that is going to take years to fix. Caused severe depression in our 11 year old. Caused serious strain on our relationships when we were all so close and this cause was [...]

— MARISSA

I survived and protected my child from being nearly killed by his father mishandling a firearm while inebriated in our home. Now they call me a liar and mentally ill and now his dad filed a false abuse case to take him away completely

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This corrupt system has destroyed us as a family unit and human beings. We have been demoralized and tormented in the most inhumane ways and will never be the same again.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

the system that was supposed to protect our children has instead been weaponized against us- worker with conflicting interests, medical information leaked.

— NICHOLE

Destroyed it broke us

— JESSICA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Removed my son under false allocations. Allowed a criminal to have sole custody of my son without reasonable visitation

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Completely ruined our family. Devastated us. I still have days where I don't know if I'll survive this.

— MCKENZI

Roanoke City CPS and family court shadder my whole life drove a wedge between me and my oldest daughter because they threatened that if she was to help me figure out how they were taking her siblings that they weren't going to return her youngest son either!!!

— TRACEY

It feels like your house is burning down and being forced to save your child with your hands tied behind your back.

— JENNIFER

The system has destroyed my family, personal relationships and professional reputation

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system is intentionally destroying family units for monetary. It has made each member of my family living in a constant survival state.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I lost contact with my daughter due to her being put with her coercive controlling father. She is continuing to struggle with her identity, emotional regulation, and mental health. My only concern is seeing her stable and happy.

— CHRISTIN

We went into family court seeking consistency and careful consideration of our concerns. Instead, our family left with trauma that has changed each of us and may never fully heal.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Didn't get treatment for one child putting her life at risk

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



This has destroyed any trust my little girl has in her daddy. She is so addicted to phone/tablet after she returned and no longer prays when before she was on fire for Christ.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system had literally ripped a wonderful, loving, beautiful family to pieces. It's turned one amazing father into a shell of himself, its caused a beautiful, outgoing, intelligent child to crawl back into his shell , and it has sent one mother into the void of darkness. [...]

— KASSIDY

Falls ligation by wife, pregnant with another man's baby post affair used allegation to gain house and Custer of children 6 months after she left and allegations made as she would have found out pregnant.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has taken a child with documented sexual and physical abuse, put him back with his abuser and taken me the protective parent out of his life. Allowing the abuser and the LCSW who has an inappropriate relationship with the father, and made it so that they get to decide when I [...]

— SIDNEY

Well it brought you here

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Awarded my abusive, suicidal husband unsupervised visitation with our son during our separation against the testimony of the supervised visitation agent. Ignored a protective order and continued violations of that order. Would not grant emergency hearings when GAL discovered [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

40 Virginia parents submitted ranked quotes. 40 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/va.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT**WHAT THIS IS**

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Virginia report comes from Virginia respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Virginia — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 61 Virginia families reporting here are not the universe of Virginia families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

STANDWITHMEG.COM | COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE.